PREP-RASHAN

A Unit of Prep-Rashan Tutorial

DAILY CURRENT AFFAIRS - RASHAN

Comprehensive Compilation for UPSC Civil Services Examination

5 November 2026

General Studies Paper I • Paper II • Paper III • Paper IV

Keywords Defined • PYQ (Prelims & Mains) • Practice Questions (Prelims & Mains)

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GENERAL STUDIES PAPER I

[GS-I] Indian Heritage & Culture, History, Geography of the World and Society

GS-I | Geography – Places in News (Mapping); Agriculture

1. Ladakh: India's First Fully Organic Union Territory

Syllabus: *GS-I: Important geographical features (mapping); distribution of agriculture. GS-III: Organic farming; environment.*

CONTEXT

Ladakh has been declared **India's first 100% organic Union Territory**: farmland in both its districts, **Leh and Kargil**, has moved away from **chemical fertilisers and synthetic pesticides**.



Green fields of Markha village in Ladakh, watered by glacier-fed channels in a cold desert valley.
Photo: Chris Hunkeler from Carlsbad, California, USA, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 2.0

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Organic farming	Farming **without synthetic fertilisers or pesticides**, using **manure, compost, crop rotation and biological pest control**.
NPOP	**National Programme for Organic Production** – India's **third-party** organic certification system, used mainly for **exports**.
PGS-India	**Participatory Guarantee System** – a **group-based, farmer-to-farmer** organic certification for the **domestic market**.
Kuhl	A traditional **glacier-fed irrigation channel** used in Ladakh and other Himalayan areas.
Cold desert	A **high, dry and very cold** region with little rain – like **Ladakh and Spiti**.

Where Ladakh lies (mapping)

- A **Trans-Himalayan** region in the far north, between the **Karakoram** range to the north and the **Great Himalaya** to the south.

- Two districts: **Leh and Kargil**; the **Indus** and its tributaries such as the **Zanskar, Shyok and Suru** flow through it.
- A **Union Territory since 31 October 2019** *(general knowledge)*.

What 'fully organic' means

- **No chemical inputs:** fertilisers, synthetic pesticides, fungicides and artificial soil additives are **phased out** on all cultivated land.
- **Conversion and certification:** a **two-to-three-year changeover**, with certification under **NPOP or PGS-India**.
- **Organic inputs: bio-fertilisers, compost, animal manure** and **biological pest control** keep soils fertile.
- **Checks: accredited agencies** and local bodies **inspect and certify** farm holdings.
- **Earlier milestone: Sikkim** became India's **first fully organic state in 2016**.

Ladakh's farm landscape

- **Cold-arid climate:** short summers, very cold winters and only **about 100 mm of rain a year** – farming depends on **kuhls**.
- **Traditional practice:** manure, compost and **crop rotation** were already common, so the shift built on **old habits**.
- **Hardy crops: hull-less barley** (locally **grim**) and **buckwheat**.
- **GI products: Raktsey Karpo apricot** and **Ladakh sea buckthorn**.
- **Food culture: khambir** (bread), **skyu** (dough stew) and **kisir** (buckwheat pancake).

Why it matters

- Protects **glacier-fed streams** and **Indus tributaries** from chemical run-off.
- Organic and **GI labels** can earn **premium prices** for farmers and **SHGs**.
- **Value addition: Paramparagat Krishi Vikas Yojana (2015)** supports PGS-based organic clusters; the **Mission Organic Value Chain Development for the North Eastern Region** supports organic farming in the North East *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **organic certification (NPOP, PGS)**, **GI tags** and **Himalayan ranges and rivers**.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **sustainable agriculture** and **fragile Himalayan ecosystems**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Consider: 1. Sikkim was India's first fully organic state. 2. Ladakh lies between the Karakoram and the Great Himalaya. 3. PGS-India is a third-party certification system for exports. Which are correct? **(Ans: 1 and 2 only)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "Organic status is easier to declare than to sustain." Discuss with reference to Ladakh's organic transition. (150 words)

GS-I | Geography – Places in News (Mapping)

2. Kedar Tal: A Glacial Lake Below Thalay Sagar

Syllabus: *GS-I: Important geographical features – glacial lakes, Himalayan peaks and rivers (mapping). GS-III: Disaster management.*

CONTEXT

A **search and rescue operation** was launched to bring back **trekkers and support staff** stranded in the **Kedar Tal** area of **Uttarkashi district, Uttarakhand**.



Kedar Tal, the glacial lake in the Garhwal Himalaya, with snow peaks reflected in its still water.
Photo: Peter Andersen, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 3.0

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Glacial lake	A lake formed by **glacier action** or fed by **glacier and snow melt**, usually at **high altitude**.
Moraine	**Rock and debris** carried and dumped by a glacier; it can **dam a lake**.
GLOF	**Glacial lake outburst flood** – a sudden flood when a glacial lake's **natural dam breaks**.
Bhojpatra	The **Himalayan birch** (*Betula utilis*), whose bark was used for **ancient manuscripts**.
Source stream	A **headwater** that joins others to form a big river – like the **Bhagirathi** for the Ganga.

Location

- A **high-altitude glacial lake** in the **Garhwal Himalaya**, in **Uttarkashi district, Uttarakhand**.
- Lies at roughly **15,600–16,000 feet** (about **4,750 m**).
- Inside the **Gangotri National Park** landscape *(general knowledge)*.

Peaks and water

- Fed by snow from peaks around it: **Thalay Sagar (6,904 m)**, **Bhrigupanth (6,772 m)** and **Meru (6,672 m)**.

- These peaks also feed the **Kedar Ganga**, which joins the **Bhagirathi** – in Hindu belief, **Lord Shiva's gift** to the Ganga's source stream.
- Known for **clear, deep-blue, icy water** framed by snow peaks.

The trek

- Starts at **Gangotri** and climbs the **Kedar Ganga gorge** via **Bhojkharak** and **Kedarkharak** to the lake.
- Passes through forests of **Himalayan birch** (*Betula utilis*, **bhojpatra**).
- **Risks:** sudden **snowfall, thin air** and **steep, loose slopes**; late-season trips can trap trekkers.

Why it matters

- Shows the need for **trekking rules, permits, weather alerts** and **rescue readiness** in high mountains.
- Glacial lakes must be **watched for GLOF risk** as glaciers melt.
- **Value addition:** the **NDMA** has guidelines on **GLOF management (2020)**; the **2013 Kedarnath disaster** involved the **Chorabari Tal** outburst *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims mapping asks about **Himalayan lakes, peaks, passes** and **river sources** (Bhagirathi, Alaknanda).

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **Himalayan disasters**, **GLOFs** and **sustainable mountain tourism**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Kedar Tal, recently in the news, is located in: (a) Kullu, Himachal Pradesh (b) Uttarkashi, Uttarakhand (c) Chamoli, Uttarakhand (d) North Sikkim **(Ans: b)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "Himalayan treks need disaster planning as much as permits." Discuss. (150 words)

GS-I | Indian Society – Women & Social Reform

3. Assam Moves to Dismiss Government Employees Practising Polygamy

Syllabus: *GS-I: Role of women; social empowerment. GS-II: Fundamental rights, personal laws, government policies.*

CONTEXT

The **Assam Cabinet** approved changes to the **Assam Services (Discipline and Appeal) Rules, 1964**, so that **government employees found practising polygamy** can be **dismissed** and **barred from future state jobs**.



Illustration: a balance weighing a wedding ring against a gavel and a rule book, with a woman standing tall – rights and accountability.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Polygamy	Being **married to more than one spouse at the same time**.
Polygyny	The commonest form of polygamy – **one man with more than one wife**.
Personal law	Family laws (marriage, divorce, inheritance) based on **religion**.
Service rules	Rules on **conduct and discipline** that bind **government employees**.
Uniform Civil Code	One **common civil law** for all citizens – a **Directive Principle (Article 44)**.

What Assam decided

- Amend the **Assam Services (Discipline and Appeal) Rules, 1964** to make **polygamy a ground for dismissal**.
- **Bar dismissed employees** from **future state government jobs**.
- **Aim:** discourage polygamy, protect **women's rights**, and ensure **ethical conduct** by public servants.

Earlier steps

- **Expert committee (2023)** headed by **Justice (Retd.) Rumi Kumari Phukan** examined whether the **state can legislate** to ban polygamy.
- The state has pursued a **law to prohibit polygamy** with **safeguards for women**.

Concerns linked to polygamy

- **Gender inequality:** can deepen **patriarchy** and leave women **vulnerable** – issues under **Articles 14 and 15**.

- **Economic insecurity:** disputes over **maintenance, inheritance and property**.
- **Legal complexity: personal laws** and **statutory marriage laws** differ, raising questions of **equality vs religious freedom**.
- **Family stress:** conflict and **unequal sharing of resources**, hurting **dependent women and children**.

The legal landscape (value addition)

- **Hindu Marriage Act, 1955** and **Special Marriage Act, 1954** require **monogamy**; bigamy is an offence under **Section 82 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita** (earlier **Section 494 IPC**).
- **Rule 21** of the **Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, 1964** already restricts **bigamous marriages** by central government servants.
- **Uttarakhand's Uniform Civil Code (2024)** prohibits polygamy *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **Directive Principles (Article 44)**, **personal laws** and **Fundamental Rights**.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **gender justice**, **personal law reform** and the **Uniform Civil Code**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Consider: 1. Polygyny means a woman having more than one husband. 2. Hindu Marriage Act, 1955 requires monogamy. 3. Article 44 asks the State to endeavour to secure a Uniform Civil Code. Which are correct? **(Ans: 2 and 3 only)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "Service rules can lead social reform, but law must carry it." Discuss with reference to Assam's move against polygamy. (150 words)

GENERAL STUDIES PAPER II

[GS-II] Governance, Constitution, Polity, Social Justice & International Relations

GS-II | International Relations / Polity – Comparing Constitutions

4. US Midterms 2026: How They Work and What They Mean for India

Syllabus: *GS-II: Comparison of the Indian constitutional scheme with other countries; India and its relations with the US; effect of other countries' policies on India.*

CONTEXT

The **2026 US midterm elections** gave the **Democratic Party** a **majority in the House of Representatives** and **control of the Senate**, returning **divided government** to Washington.

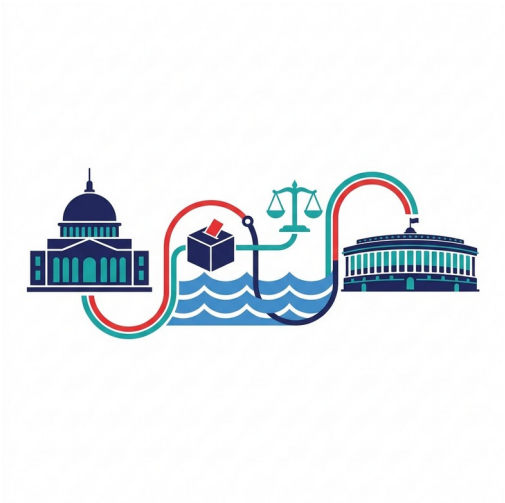


Illustration: a domed legislature linked across an ocean to India's Parliament by a ballot box and a balance – elections and their impact on ties.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Midterm election	US federal election held **halfway through a president's four-year term**.
Divided government	When the **President's party does not control Congress**.
Power of the purse	Congress's power to **raise and spend money** – **Article I** of the US Constitution.
Advice and consent	The **Senate's power to confirm** judges, ambassadors and cabinet nominees.
FPTP	**First-past-the-post** – the candidate with the **most votes** in a constituency wins.

How US midterms work

- Held **every four years**, at the **midpoint** of the presidential term, in **early November**.
- **House:** all **435 voting seats** are contested for **two-year terms**.
- **Senate:** about **one-third** of the **100 seats** (33–35) are contested for **six-year terms**.

- Held alongside contests for **36 governorships**, state legislatures and local **referendums**.
- Seen as a **referendum on the sitting President**.

How results shape presidential power

- **Legislative agenda:** an opposition Congress controls **committee chairs** and the **calendar**.
- **Budget control:** money bills start in the **House**; Congress can **cap or condition** spending, including on foreign conflicts.
- **Oversight:** committees can **summon officials** and **subpoena records**.
- **Confirmations:** the Senate can **delay or reject** nominees.
- **Sanctions:** Congress can pass **binding sanctions laws** that limit presidential waivers.

US vs India: electoral systems

- **System:** US – **presidential**, strict separation of powers; India – **parliamentary**, executive answerable to the **Lok Sabha**.
- **Heads:** US President is **head of state and government**; India separates the **President** and the **Prime Minister**.
- **Midterms:** fixed in the US; India has **no fixed midterm** – only early polls on **dissolution**.
- **Houses:** House **435** (2 years) and Senate **100** (6 years) vs **Lok Sabha 543** (5 years) and **Rajya Sabha 245** (6 years).
- **Management:** US polls run by **50 states** under local laws; India's by the **Election Commission (Article 324)**.

Implications for India

- **Energy security:** closer scrutiny of **war powers** may push **de-escalation in the Gulf** – safer **Hormuz** shipping for India's **crude, LNG and fertiliser**.
- **Trade:** pressure against **inflationary tariffs** may help close the **India–US trade agreement**.
- **Russian oil:** bipartisan support for **secondary sanctions** means India must **engage both parties** to keep exemptions.
- **Diaspora:** softer **immigration rhetoric** may help the **Indian-American community**.
- **Way ahead:** build **bipartisan coalitions** in Congress, not only ties with the executive.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks to **compare the Indian and US constitutions** (impeachment, upper houses, judicial review).

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **India–US relations** and the **presidential vs parliamentary** systems.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Consider: 1. All 435 voting seats of the US House of Representatives are contested every two years. 2. US Senators serve four-year terms. 3. In India, elections are conducted by the Election Commission under Article 324. Which are correct? **(Ans: 1 and 3 only)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "Divided government in Washington changes the terrain for New Delhi." Discuss the implications of the 2026 US midterms for India. (250 words)

GS-II | Social Justice – Health & Nutrition

5. Anaemia: Why Iron Alone Is Not the Answer

Syllabus: *GS-II: Issues relating to health and human resources; nutrition; government schemes for vulnerable sections.*

CONTEXT

Double-Fortified Salt (DFS) – salt with both **iron and iodine** – is being proposed to fight **anaemia**, but experts warn that iron explains only **part of the problem** and that DFS carries **risks**.



Illustration: a red blood cell with leafy greens, eggs, pulses, a salt shaker and a stethoscope – many causes, many cures.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Anaemia	**Haemoglobin below normal**, so blood carries **less oxygen**.
Haem and non-haem iron	**Haem iron** (from meat, fish) is absorbed well; **non-haem iron** (from plants) is absorbed poorly.
Hepcidin	A **hormone** that rises during **infection or inflammation** and **blocks iron absorption**.
Haemoglobinopathy	An **inherited blood disorder** – e.g., **thalassaemia** and **sickle cell disease**.
Ferritin	A protein that stores iron; its blood level shows the body's **iron reserves**.

The burden

- **NFHS-5:** more than **half of women** and about **two-thirds of young children** are anaemic.
- **Iron deficiency** affects about **31% of under-five children**, **36% of women** and **28% of all people** *(as cited)*.
- Globally, only about **half of anaemia** is due to **iron deficiency**; the **CNNS (2016–18)** found a similar picture among Indian children.
- **Most at risk:** adolescent girls, pregnant women, young children and **poor rural households**.
- **Effects:** higher **maternal and child deaths**, harm to **brain development and learning**, lower **work capacity**.

What India does

- **Anaemia Mukt Bharat: iron and folic acid (IFA)** tablets – coverage and compliance remain weak.
- **Fortified rice** through the **PDS, PM POSHAN and ICDS**.

- **Wheat flour fortification** with iron, folic acid and vitamin B12 in partnership with mills.
- **Double-Fortified Salt** – iron plus iodine in a food everyone uses.

Concerns about DFS

- **Salt goal clash:** Indians eat about **twice** the **5 g a day** WHO limit; about **one in three adults** has **high blood pressure**; India targets a **30% cut** in salt intake.
- **Unequal dose: men** eat the most salt; **women and children**, who need iron most, eat the least.
- **Iron overload:** the body cannot excrete extra iron – risky for people with **thalassaemia**; **sickle cell** is common in **tribal areas**.
- **Stacked exposure:** rice, IFA tablets and DFS together may give children iron from **three or four schemes** at once.
- **Poor absorption: phytates** (cereals, pulses), **tea and coffee polyphenols** and **calcium** reduce absorption; **infection-driven hepcidin** blocks it.
- **Evidence of harm:** the **2006 Pemba trial (Tanzania)** linked iron supplements to more child deaths in a **malaria** area; a **2015 Kenyan** study found more **harmful gut bacteria** in infants.

Way forward

- **District pilots** of DFS with checks on **haemoglobin, ferritin and inflammation** before any national roll-out.
- **Count total iron** from all schemes; prefer **targeted** fortification.
- **Better diagnosis:** test **ferritin, vitamin B12** and inflammation, not just haemoglobin.
- **Diverse diets:** affordable **eggs, dairy, greens, pulses and millets**.
- **Infection control: deworming, malaria control, WASH**.
- **Global lessons: Peru** (supplements, micronutrient powders, cash transfers) and **Vietnam** (weekly supplements, deworming, **iron-fortified fish sauce**).

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **micronutrients**, **fortification**, **NFHS** findings and **nutrition schemes**.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **malnutrition, hidden hunger** and the **effectiveness of nutrition programmes**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Consider: 1. Hepcidin levels rise during infection and block iron absorption. 2. Haem iron from plant foods is absorbed better than non-haem iron. 3. Double-Fortified Salt contains iron and iodine. Which are correct? **(Ans: 1 and 3 only)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "Anaemia is not only an iron problem." Examine the causes of anaemia in India and why iron fortification alone cannot solve it. (250 words)

GS-II | Polity – Judiciary & Justice Delivery

6. Fast Track Special Courts Extended Till 2031

Syllabus: *GS-II: Structure and functioning of the judiciary; welfare schemes for vulnerable sections; mechanisms for protection of women and children.*

CONTEXT

The **Union Cabinet** approved continuing the **Centrally Sponsored Scheme for Fast Track Special Courts (FTSCs)**, including **exclusive POCSO courts**, for **five years** – **1 April 2026 to 31 March 2031**.



Illustration: a small courtroom with a gavel and a clock, next to a child-friendly room with a soft chair and toys.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
FTSC	**Fast Track Special Court** – a dedicated court only for **rape and POCSO** cases.
POCSO Act, 2012	**Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act** – a special law for child sexual abuse.
Centrally Sponsored Scheme	A scheme run by **States** with **shared central funding**.
In-camera trial	A hearing held **in private**, to protect victims.
VWDC	**Vulnerable Witness Deposition Centre** – a safe space where children can testify **without facing the accused**.

Background

- Linked to the **Criminal Law (Amendment) Act, 2018**, which set **time-bound trials** (within **two months**) for rape.
- The **Supreme Court (25 July 2019)** ordered **special POCSO courts** in districts with **over 100 pending POCSO cases**.
- Launched on **2 October 2019** by the **Department of Justice (Ministry of Law and Justice)**.
- **So far:** about **779 functional FTSCs**, including **399 exclusive POCSO courts**, in **29 States/UTs**, have disposed of over **4 lakh cases** *(as cited)*.

How an FTSC is staffed and run

- **One judicial officer** (Sessions or Additional Sessions Judge level), **one Special Public Prosecutor** and **six support staff**.
- **Exclusive jurisdiction:** only **rape and POCSO** cases, with **daily hearings**.
- **Targets:** about **41–42 cases a quarter** and **at least 165 a year** per court.
- **Child-friendly: VWDCs** and **in-camera** trials.
- **Monitoring:** an **online FTSC dashboard** run by the Department of Justice with **High Courts**; victim **compensation** and **counselling** links.

Significance and concerns

- Upholds the **right to a speedy trial (Article 21)** and **equal access to justice (Article 39A)**.
- **Reduces pendency** and the **secondary trauma** of long trials.
- **Concerns: vacant posts**, shortage of **forensic labs**, and speed that must never cost **fair trial rights**.
- **Value addition:** the scheme is funded from the **Nirbhaya Fund**; the **BNSS, 2023** sets timelines for investigation in sexual offences *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **POCSO**, **Nirbhaya Fund**, **Article 39A** and **judicial pendency** measures.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **judicial delays** and **justice for women and children**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Fast Track Special Courts under the Centrally Sponsored Scheme deal exclusively with: (a) economic offences (b) rape and POCSO cases (c) cheque bounce cases (d) motor accident claims **(Ans: b)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "Speedy justice for survivors must not mean hurried justice." Evaluate the working of Fast Track Special Courts. (150 words)

GS-II | Polity – Parliament & Financial Accountability

7. Public Accounts Committee: Conference on Audit and Accountability

Syllabus: *GS-II: Parliament – structure, functioning, business; parliamentary committees; constitutional bodies (CAG).*

CONTEXT

A national **Conference of Chairpersons of Public Accounts Committees** of **Parliament and State/UT legislatures** was held in **Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala**, on the **evolving role of the PAC** in **audit, accountability and good governance**.



The new Parliament House in New Delhi, home of the Public Accounts Committee of Parliament.
Photo: Ministry of Parliamentary Affairs, Wikimedia Commons, GODL-India

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
PAC	**Public Accounts Committee** – Parliament's **oldest financial committee**, which checks **how public money was spent**.
CAG	**Comptroller and Auditor General** – the constitutional auditor (**Articles 148–151**).
Appropriation accounts	Accounts showing spending **against the grants voted** by Parliament.
ATN	**Action Taken Note** – a ministry's reply on what it did about audit or PAC findings.
PR-STV	**Proportional representation by single transferable vote** – the method used to elect PAC members.

About the PAC

- First set up in **1921** under the **Government of India Act, 1919** (**Montagu–Chelmsford reforms**).
- Now functions under **Rule 308** of the **Lok Sabha Rules of Procedure**.
- **22 members** in all – **Lok Sabha 15**, **Rajya Sabha 7** – chosen **every year** by **PR-STV**.
- **No Minister** can be a member; the **Chairperson** is appointed by the **Speaker** – by convention since **1967**, from the **Opposition**.

What it does

- Examines **CAG reports (Article 151)** – appropriation, finance and audit reports.
- Checks money was spent **within the grant** and **for the purpose** voted.
- Examines **excess expenditure** and recommends its **regularisation** by Parliament.
- Looks at **economy and propriety** – waste and irregularities.
- Follows up through **Action Taken Notes** and reports to the House.

Resolutions of the 2026 conference

- **Uniform deadlines** for ministries to submit **ATNs**.
- A digital **Audit Para Monitoring System (APMS)** in all State/UT legislatures.
- Closer work with the **CAG** using **forensic audit, AI and data analytics**.
- **At least three PAC sittings a month** and specialised **sub-committees**.
- A shared **digital knowledge portal** and **training** for all PACs.

Value addition

- The **Estimates Committee** (30 members, all Lok Sabha) and the **Committee on Public Undertakings** (22 members) are the other two financial committees.
- The CAG is called the **'friend, philosopher and guide'** of the PAC *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **financial committees** – their **size, composition, chair** and links with the **CAG**.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **parliamentary oversight** and the **role of committees** in accountability.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Consider: 1. The PAC has members from both Houses of Parliament. 2. A Minister can be elected as a member of the PAC. 3. The PAC examines the audit reports of the CAG. Which are correct? **(Ans: 1 and 3 only)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "The PAC is the watchdog's watchdog." Discuss its role and suggest ways to strengthen it. (150 words)

GS-II | Governance – Statistics & Data Systems

8. VISTAR: A ₹4,371-Crore Upgrade for India's Statistical System

Syllabus: *GS-II: Government policies and interventions; e-governance and transparency. GS-III: Indian economy – measurement of growth.*

CONTEXT

The **Union Cabinet** approved **VISTAR** – the **Viksit Bharat Initiative for Statistical Transformation, Analytics and Research** – a **Central Sector Scheme** for **2026–27 to 2030–31** with an outlay of about **₹4,371 crore**.



Illustration: dashboards, maps and charts fed by survey clipboards and a satellite – data for better policy.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Central Sector Scheme	A scheme **fully funded and run by the Centre**.
Economic Census	A count of **all non-farm establishments** in the country.
PLFS	**Periodic Labour Force Survey** – India's main source of **jobs data**.
HCES	**Household Consumption Expenditure Survey** – used to measure **spending and poverty**.
Big data	Very large, fast-moving datasets – e.g., **mobile location, barcode scans, e-commerce**.

What VISTAR is

- A **flagship scheme** that brings all **central statistical operations** under one umbrella.
- **Ministry: Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI)**.
- **Three parts: core statistical operations**, **Support for Statistical Strengthening (SSS 2.0)** for States, and the **8th Economic Census**.
- **Aim:** a modern system using **AI, machine learning** and **linked datasets** for **timely, reliable** indicators.

Key features

- **More surveys:** major surveys rise from **43 to 59** during the **16th Finance Commission** period, with **digital collection** and **AI checks**.

- **New indicators:** a **Headline Index of Services Production** and an **Index of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises**.
- **Big data: mobile location data, barcode scans** and **e-commerce** records to supplement surveys.
- **SSS 2.0:** performance-linked grants for **district GDP**, **State IIP** and local **PLFS, HCES and ASUSE** estimates.
- **8th Economic Census:** counts non-farm units down to **Gram Panchayat and urban ward**, feeding a **Statistical Business Register**.

Why it matters

- **Granular data** helps design **district-level** policies.
- Better coverage of the **informal sector** improves **GDP** and **jobs** estimates.
- **Value addition:** the **7th Economic Census** was held in **2019–20**; the **National Statistical Office** was formed in **2019** by merging the **CSO and NSSO** *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **who publishes which data** (GDP, IIP, CPI, PLFS) and **survey bodies**.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about the **credibility of official statistics** and **evidence-based policy**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- The VISTAR scheme, recently approved, is related to: (a) river interlinking (b) strengthening the statistical system (c) space science outreach (d) rural road connectivity **(Ans: b)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "Good policy needs good data." Discuss how the VISTAR scheme can improve India's statistical system. (150 words)

GS-II | International Relations – Groupings (Commonwealth)

9. CHOGM 2026 in Antigua and Barbuda

Syllabus: *GS-II: Important international institutions and groupings; India's foreign policy.*

CONTEXT

India was represented by the **External Affairs Minister** at the **Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting (CHOGM) 2026** in **St John's, Antigua and Barbuda**, where India highlighted its **digital public infrastructure** and **trade agreements**.



Illustration: a round table with many chairs on a Caribbean coastline – nations meeting as equals.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
CHOGM	**Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting** – the Commonwealth's **top forum**, held **every two years**.
Commonwealth	A **voluntary association** of **56 independent countries**, mostly **former British territories**.
London Declaration (1949)	The decision that created the **modern Commonwealth** of free and equal members.
Communiqué	The **official joint statement** issued at the end of a summit.
Small states	Countries with **small populations**, often **islands** vulnerable to **climate change**.

About CHOGM

- The Commonwealth's **main forum** for dialogue and **collective decisions**.
- **First held in 1971** (Singapore); leaders meet **every two years**, hosted by members **in rotation**.
- **India hosted CHOGM in 1983** in New Delhi *(general knowledge)*.

Highlights of CHOGM 2026

- **Host: St John's**, capital of **Antigua and Barbuda** (Caribbean).
- **Theme: accelerating partnerships and investment** for a **prosperous Commonwealth**.

- **Focus: climate resilience, trade, innovation, equality** and **sustainable development**.
- **Side meetings:** a **ministerial meeting on small states** and a **foreign ministers' meeting** (1–2 November).
- **Investment:** over **US$500 million** in new pledges for **renewable energy, youth skills** and **trade**.

About the Commonwealth

- **56 members**; the newest are **Gabon and Togo (2022)**.
- **Headquarters: Marlborough House, London**.
- **Bodies: Commonwealth Secretariat**, **Commonwealth Foundation**, a **Secretary-General** and a **Board of Governors**.
- Holds **observer status** at the **UN General Assembly**; the **British monarch** is its **symbolic head**.

India and the Commonwealth

- India is the **largest member** by population and economy.
- India's **DPI** and **trade deals** are useful models for **small and developing** members.
- **Value addition:** the **2024 CHOGM** was in **Apia, Samoa** – the first in a **Pacific island state** *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **international groupings** – members, headquarters and founding years.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about the **relevance of the Commonwealth** and India's role in it.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Consider: 1. The Commonwealth has 56 members. 2. Its headquarters is at Marlborough House, London. 3. CHOGM is held every year. Which are correct? **(Ans: 1 and 2 only)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "The Commonwealth can matter again as a platform for small states." Discuss India's role in it. (150 words)

GENERAL STUDIES PAPER III

[GS-III] Technology, Economic Development, Bio-diversity, Environment, Security & Disaster Management

GS-III | Indian Economy – Poverty, Inequality & Household Security

10. Out of Poverty, but Financially Secure?

Syllabus: *GS-III: Indian economy – poverty, inclusive growth, employment. GS-II: Welfare schemes; health.*

CONTEXT

India's **fall in poverty** is one of the **fastest anywhere**, but crossing a poverty line does not mean **lasting security** – many families still face **unstable earnings, debt, thin savings and health costs**.



Illustration: households climbing a staircase from a hut to a sturdy house, with a piggy bank, a hospital cross and a broken debt chain.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Extreme poverty	Living below the **World Bank's international line** – now **$3 a day** at **2021 PPP**.
PPP	**Purchasing power parity** – compares incomes by what money **actually buys** in each country.
MPCE	**Monthly per capita consumption expenditure** – average spending per person per month.
Gini coefficient	A measure of **inequality** from **0 (equal)** to **1 (most unequal)**.
Out-of-pocket expenditure	Health spending paid **directly by households** at the time of care.

The progress

- **Extreme poverty** ($3 a day) fell from **27.1% (2011–12)** to **2.6% (2023–24)** *(World Bank)*.
- At the **$4.20 line**, poverty fell from **57.7% to 16.1%**; about **233 million** people are still below it; it is projected to fall from **14.2% (2026)** to **12.1% (2028)**.
- **Kerala** became the first state to **declare itself free of extreme poverty**.

- **Drivers:** three decades of **growth after 1991**, **rural job guarantee**, **cash transfers**, **free grain** for about **800 million**, **housing, toilets** and **tap water** (rural piped water from under **17% in 2019** to about **82%**).
- **Caution:** the **2011–12 NSS** and **2023–24 HCES** surveys differ in **design**, so comparisons need care.

Better living standards

- **Electricity: 67.9% → 98.3%** of people (2005–06 to 2023–24); **sanitation 47.6% → 89%**; **clean cooking fuel 28.5% → 71.6%**.
- **Bank or post office accounts: 40.2% → 98.2%**; women's internet use **33.3% → 64.3%** (NFHS-5 to NFHS-6).
- **Spending:** MPCE of about **₹4,122 (rural)** and **₹6,996 (urban)** in 2023–24.
- **Consumption Gini** fell: rural **0.266 → 0.237**, urban **0.314 → 0.284**.

Why security is still fragile

- **Debt:** rural households with debt rose from **47.4% to 52%** (NABARD, 2016–17 to 2021–22), even as incomes rose **57.6%**.
- **Farm income:** real income from **crop cultivation fell 10.4%**; **wages** are now the largest share of farm household income.
- **Jobs: self-employment (58.4%)** includes **unpaid family work**; regular wage jobs **slipped** to **21.7%**.
- **Health costs:** government's share of health spending rose to **43.7%**, but public health spending is still only about **1% of GDP**.
- **Inequality:** the **top 10%** get about **58%** of national income, the **bottom 50% only 15%**; **youth unemployment** rose to **15.2%** (March 2026).

Way forward

- **Progressive taxation** and **universal quality schools and hospitals**.
- **Farm productivity**, **industrial jobs** and smooth **rural-to-urban** transition.
- **Better-targeted food subsidies** for **nutrition**, not only calories.
- India's **own updated poverty line** and a **regular, comparable** survey series.
- **Value addition:** NITI Aayog's **Multidimensional Poverty Index** reported about **24.8 crore** people moving out of MPI poverty between **2013–14 and 2022–23** *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **poverty lines and committees** (Tendulkar, Rangarajan), **MPI** and **inequality measures**.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **inclusive growth**, **inequality** and **jobless growth**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Consider: 1. The World Bank's current extreme poverty line is $3 a day at 2021 PPP. 2. A Gini coefficient of 1 means perfect equality. 3. Kerala has declared itself free of extreme poverty. Which are correct? **(Ans: 1 and 3 only)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "Crossing the poverty line is not the same as financial security." Discuss with reference to recent trends in India. (250 words)

GS-III | Indian Economy – Regional Development (North East)

11. The North East as an Engine of India's Growth

Syllabus: *GS-III: Indian economy – inclusive growth, infrastructure, investment. GS-II: Federalism; Act East Policy.*

CONTEXT

With **almost all of its boundary touching other countries**, the **eight North Eastern states** can become a **major growth engine** on the road to **Viksit Bharat 2047** – through **nature, people and culture** – if treated as a **family of diverse states**, not one block.



Illustration: green hills with tea gardens, bamboo, a river bridge and a train, a handloom and a compass pointing east.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Act East Policy	India's policy (**2014**) of deeper **economic and strategic ties** with **South-East Asia**.
DoNER	**Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region**.
GI tag	A **geographical indication** showing a product's quality comes from **its place**.
Fiscal devolution	Sharing of **central tax revenue** with States on the **Finance Commission's** formula.
Land port	A **border crossing** with customs and trade facilities for **road and rail cargo**.

Why the region can lead

- **Nature:** about **two-thirds** of the region is **forest**; **community ownership** of land and forests keeps benefits local.
- **Models: Sikkim's organic farming**, **Meghalaya's Lakadong turmeric** and **Khonoma village (Nagaland)** conservation.
- **People:** high **female work participation**, **Mizoram's** strong **literacy**, and **English** skills useful for **global services**; sporting talent like **Mary Kom, Mirabai Chanu, Lovlina Borgohain**.
- **Culture: Assam tea, Muga silk**, handlooms, **bamboo crafts**; events like the **Hornbill Festival**.
- **Location:** about **98%** of its boundaries are **international** – a **gateway** to **South and South-East Asia**.

What has been done

- **Act East Policy (2014)**.
- **Connectivity: Bogibeel Bridge**, **Dhola–Sadiya Bridge** and **Sela Tunnel**.
- **Money:** DoNER spending from about **₹1,000 crore (2022–23)** to a **₹6,500-crore** allocation in **2026–27** *(as cited)*.
- **Investment:** the **Rising Northeast Investors Summit** drew interest of over **₹4 lakh crore**.
- **Forests counted:** the **Finance Commission** now gives weight to **forest cover** in sharing resources.

What more is needed

- **Trade:** stable **cross-border** arrangements for **land ports, waterways** and **corridors**.
- **Finance: performance-linked** incentives, **credit guarantees** and **risk-sharing** for local entrepreneurs – while respecting **community land tenure**.
- **Green reward:** fiscal transfers that **reward forest and watershed protection**.
- **Jobs:** turn **investment pledges** into **real enterprises**; promote **tourism, handlooms and bamboo**.
- **Value addition:** the **Siliguri Corridor** ('chicken's neck', about **22 km** wide) links the region to the rest of India; the **North Eastern Council** was set up in **1971** *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **NE geography** (passes, rivers, national parks) and **GI products**.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **development and security of the North East** and the **Act East Policy**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Consider: 1. Lakadong turmeric is associated with Meghalaya. 2. Muga silk is associated with Assam. 3. The Act East Policy was launched in 1991. Which are correct? **(Ans: 1 and 2 only)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "From periphery to powerhouse." Discuss the potential of the North East as an engine of India's growth and the role of the Centre. (250 words)

GS-III | Environment – Climate Finance & Carbon Markets

12. BRICS Carbon Markets Partnership: Framework Before Trading

Syllabus: *GS-III: Environment – climate change, conservation; international agreements. GS-II: Groupings (BRICS).*

CONTEXT

The **18th BRICS Summit in New Delhi** reaffirmed the plan to put into action the **MoU on the BRICS Carbon Markets Partnership** – but its success depends on a **common framework**, not just a **shared trading platform**.



Illustration: hands fitting puzzle pieces around a globe, with carbon credit tokens and a green leaf.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Carbon credit	A tradable unit for **one tonne of CO_2 (or equivalent)** reduced or removed.
Cap-and-trade	A system with an **overall emissions cap**; firms **trade permits** within it.
Intensity target	A limit on **emissions per unit of output**, not on total emissions.
MRV	**Measurement, reporting and verification** of emissions.
CBAM	The **EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism** – a carbon charge on certain **imports**.

Where BRICS carbon markets stand

- **Different designs: China and India** use **emission-intensity benchmarks**; **Brazil** uses an **absolute cap**.
- **China:** a **compliance market** now covering **steel, cement and aluminium**.
- **India:** the **Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS)** has notified **intensity targets** for **490 entities** in **nine sectors**.
- **Brazil:** a **2024 law** set up a **cap-and-trade** system (**SBCE**).
- **South Africa, Indonesia** and others run **voluntary markets** and host offset projects.

Hurdles to linking

- **Rules differ:** benchmarks, compliance and **pricing**.

- **Legal status differs:** carbon units are **securities in Brazil**; in India, certificates trade on **power exchanges** under **CERC** rules.
- **Little mutual recognition** of each other's credits.
- **No common MRV** – credits are hard to compare.
- **Outside pressure: CBAM** (EU, then the UK) demands **verified emissions data** from exporters.
- **Double-counting** risks without clear **corresponding adjustments**.

What to build

- **A common MRV framework** with comparable accounting, **default values** and **interoperable registries**.
- **A BRICS rulebook** aligned with **ISO 14064**, **mutual recognition of verifiers**, harmonised **registry data**.
- **A joint answer to CBAM**: credible data so exporters avoid **punitive default values**.
- **A small pilot exchange** under **Article 6.2 of the Paris Agreement**; India's **Joint Crediting Mechanism with Japan** is a model.
- **Institutions:** the **New Development Bank** could host a **shared registry** or buy pilot credits.
- **Value addition:** the CCTS was notified in **2023** under the **Energy Conservation Act, 2001** (amended **2022**), with the **Bureau of Energy Efficiency** as administrator *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **carbon markets**, **Paris Agreement Article 6**, **CBAM** and **BRICS institutions** (NDB).

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **climate finance** and **trade–climate** linkages.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Consider: 1. Brazil's new carbon market is a cap-and-trade system. 2. India's CCTS sets emission-intensity targets. 3. Article 6.2 of the Paris Agreement deals with adaptation finance. Which are correct? **(Ans: 1 and 2 only)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "A common framework must come before a common market." Discuss with reference to the BRICS Carbon Markets Partnership. (250 words)

GS-III | Indian Economy – Critical Minerals & Industrial Policy **UPDATE**

13. ₹2,814-Crore Capex Support for Critical Mineral Processing

Syllabus: *GS-III: Indian economy – industrial policy, mobilisation of resources; energy; security of supply chains.*

WHAT WE KNOW TILL NOW

- India is building a **strategic stockpile of critical minerals**, but a stockpile alone cannot fix the **processing gap**.
- A **₹7,280-crore scheme** supports **6,000 tonnes a year** of **rare-earth permanent magnet** capacity.
- The **National Critical Mineral Mission (2025)**, a list of **30 critical minerals (2023)** and **KABIL** (assets abroad) are the main tools.

WHAT TODAY ADDS

- A new **₹2,814-crore capital subsidy** for **lithium and nickel processing plants**, with **cobalt** as a by-product.
- How the support is capped, how beneficiaries are chosen and how money is released.

CONTEXT

A **₹2,814-crore Capex Support Scheme to Promote Critical Mineral Processing** got **Union Cabinet** approval; it runs from **2026–27 to 2030–31** and aims to build **domestic refining** and cut **import dependence**.

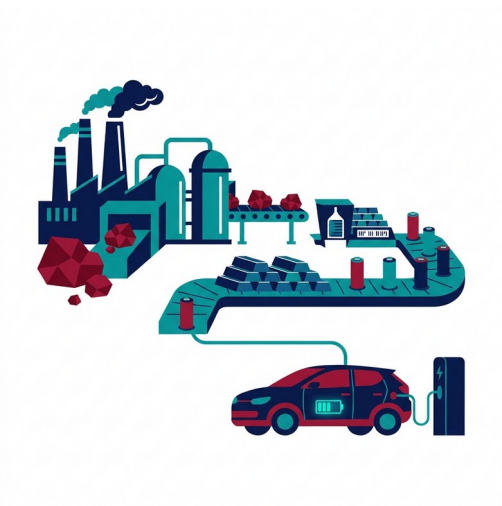


Illustration: a refinery turning ore into battery cells, with lithium and nickel ingots and an electric car charging.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Capex	**Capital expenditure** – money spent on **plants, machines and buildings**.
Beneficiation	**Upgrading ore** by removing waste before refining.
Battery-grade	Material pure enough for **battery cells** (e.g., lithium carbonate or hydroxide).
ACC	**Advanced chemistry cell** – modern rechargeable battery cells for **EVs and grid storage**.

Keyword	Meaning
BESS	**Battery energy storage system** – large batteries that store power for the **grid**.

The scheme

- **Ministry: Mines**; **outlay ₹2,814 crore**; **five years** (FY 2026–27 to 2030–31).
- **Minerals: lithium** and **nickel**, plus **cobalt** recovered from **nickel refining**.
- **Subsidy: 30% of eligible capital investment**.
- **Four plants: two lithium** (at least **30 kt** each, support capped at **₹500 crore** each) and **two nickel** (at least **50 kt** each, capped at **₹900 crore** each).

How it works

- **Two-stage selection: technical qualification**, then **financial bidding** on the **least-cost** basis.
- **Three milestone tranches** linked to **construction and commissioning**.
- **Downstream link:** outputs feed **ACC battery** factories, **EVs**, **grid BESS**, **defence** and **specialty steel**.

Why it matters

- Cuts reliance on **China-dominated refining** and exposure to **export curbs** and **price swings**.
- Joins **exploration** to **EV and clean-energy manufacturing** – **Aatmanirbhar Bharat** and **decarbonisation**.
- **Challenges: assured ore supply** (much must be **imported**), **technology**, **water and effluent** management.
- **Value addition:** the **PLI scheme for ACC batteries (2021)** – about **₹18,100 crore** for **50 GWh** – creates the demand these plants will serve *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **critical minerals**, their **uses** and **schemes** like PLI and NCMM.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **mineral security** and **energy transition supply chains**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Under the Capex Support Scheme for critical mineral processing, which mineral is to be recovered as a by-product? (a) Graphite (b) Cobalt (c) Copper (d) Vanadium **(Ans: b)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "Processing, not mining, is India's critical-mineral bottleneck." Discuss with reference to recent schemes. (150 words)

GS-III | Internal Security – Defence Recruitment

14. Agnipath Revamped: A Pathway for Every Willing Agniveer

Syllabus: *GS-III: Security forces and their mandate; defence reforms. GS-II: Government policies.*

CONTEXT

The **Union Cabinet** approved a major change to the **Agnipath scheme**, creating a route for the **absorption of all willing Agniveers** into the **regular Armed Forces**.



Illustration: young soldiers marching in silhouette beside a rising career ladder and a shield.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Agniveer	A soldier, sailor or airman recruited under **Agnipath** on a **fixed tenure**.
PBOR	**Personnel below officer rank**.
Seva Nidhi	A **savings corpus** built from the Agniveer's and the **government's equal contributions**.
Second engagement	The new **two-year extension** after the first four years.
Absorption	Being taken into **regular, permanent service**.

The original scheme (2022)

- Launched in **June 2022** by the **Ministry of Defence** to recruit **PBOR** for the **Army, Navy and Air Force**.
- **Four-year tenure**, including **six months of training**; age **17½ to 21** (a one-time relaxation to **23** in 2022) *(general knowledge)*.
- **Pay:** from **₹30,000** a month in year one to **₹40,000** in year four.
- **Seva Nidhi: 30% of pay** matched by the Centre – a **tax-free** exit amount of about **₹11.71 lakh**.
- **₹48 lakh** life insurance; women recruited in more streams.
- Originally, **up to 25%** were to be retained after four years.

What changes now

- **Second engagement:** a **two-year extension** for the **75%** not selected at year four – **six years** in all.

- **Full absorption route:** after that, **all willing Agniveers** who meet the criteria join as **regular soldiers** – no forced exit.
- **Higher pay** during the extension than the year-four level.
- **Bigger Seva Nidhi** for the longer tenure.
- **Seniority protection** and career benefits on entering the regular cadre.

Significance

- Keeps **trained, experienced** soldiers and saves **training investment**.
- Answers concerns about **morale, job security** and **unit cohesion** raised in reviews.
- Retains the aim of a **younger, tech-savvy force** (average age down by **4–5 years**).
- **Value addition:** several **CAPFs and States** reserve posts or relax age limits for **ex-Agniveers** (*general knowledge*).

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **defence reforms**, **recruitment schemes** and **tri-service** bodies.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **defence manpower reform** and **modernisation**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Consider: 1. Agnipath recruits personnel below officer rank. 2. The Seva Nidhi is built from equal contributions by the Agniveer and the government. 3. Under the revamp, Agniveers not selected at year four get a two-year extension. Which are correct? **(Ans: 1, 2 and 3)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "The revamped Agnipath balances youth with experience." Discuss. (150 words)

GS-III | Science & Technology – Telecom Regulation

15. Network Anubhav: TRAI's Map of Real Network Quality

Syllabus: *GS-III: Science and technology – IT and communications; infrastructure. GS-II: Regulatory bodies; consumer protection.*

CONTEXT

The **Network Anubhav Platform**, now live from the telecom regulator **TRAI**, is a **geospatial dashboard** that shows **real network performance** and gives web access to **Do Not Disturb (DND)** services.



Illustration: a smartphone showing a coverage map with signal dots, towers and a speed gauge.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Geospatial	Data **linked to a location on a map**.
QoS	**Quality of service** – speed, call drops, latency.
Percentile speed	The speed that a set share of tests **reaches or exceeds** – e.g., **P50** is the **median**.
Crowdsourced data	Data contributed by **many users** (e.g., speed tests on their phones).
DND	**Do Not Disturb** – a service to **block unwanted commercial calls and SMS**.

What it is

- A **GIS-based dashboard** of **mobile and broadband** performance across India.
- **Data:** tests by users on TRAI's **MySpeed** and **MyCall** apps plus TRAI's **Independent Drive Tests (IDT)**.
- **Run by TRAI**, the statutory regulator under the **Ministry of Communications**.

Key features

- **Interactive maps:** filter by **operator, place, 4G/5G**, **download/upload** speed; zoom, tables and **downloadable reports**.
- **Realistic speeds: P50 (median)**, **P80 (mobile)** and **P90 (fixed broadband)** instead of **advertised peaks**.
- **DND 3.0 on the web:** set preferences, **report spam** and **track complaints**; see operator-wise **spam trends**.
- **Operator dashboard:** secure access to **call-drop, coverage-gap and latency** data.

- **MySpeed SDK:** lets approved apps add **speed tests**, widening coverage.

Why it matters

- Helps consumers **compare operators** and **demand better service**.
- Helps TRAI find **coverage gaps**, judge **5G performance** and act on **spam**.
- **Value addition:** TRAI was set up under the **TRAI Act, 1997**; spam rules are in the **Telecom Commercial Communications Customer Preference Regulations, 2018** *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **regulators** (TRAI, TDSAT), **5G** and **consumer protection** in telecom.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **digital connectivity** and **regulatory transparency**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- The Network Anubhav Platform has been launched by: (a) Department of Telecommunications (b) TRAI (c) BSNL (d) C-DOT **(Ans: b)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "Transparency is a regulator's strongest tool." Discuss with reference to TRAI's Network Anubhav Platform. (150 words)

GS-III | Environment – Species in News

16. Indian Gaur Recorded at a Record 3,542 m in Sikkim

Syllabus: *GS-III: Conservation – species, habitats and protected areas; climate change and species ranges.*

CONTEXT

A **camera-trap study** in **eastern Sikkim** photographed a **gaur at 3,542 m** – the **highest verified photographic record** of the species anywhere.



A gaur in Kanha National Park, Madhya Pradesh – the world's largest wild cattle.
Photo: Charles J. Sharp, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Gaur	*Bos gaurus*, the **Indian bison** – the **largest wild bovine** in the world.
Bovidae	The family of **cattle, buffaloes, goats, sheep and antelopes**.
Camera trap	A camera fired by **motion or heat** to photograph wildlife.
Diurnal / nocturnal	**Active by day** / **active by night**.
Range shift	A species moving to **new areas or heights**, often due to **climate or disturbance**.

About the gaur

- Also called the **Indian bison**; the **largest living wild bovine**; family **Bovidae**.
- **State animal** of **Goa** and **Bihar** *(as cited)*.
- **Native** to **South and South-East Asia**.
- **Looks:** huge body, **muscular shoulder hump**; **both sexes have horns**; adult males **black**, females **dark brown**.

Habitat and behaviour

- **Evergreen, semi-evergreen and moist deciduous** forests with **grassy openings**; usually **below 1,500–1,800 m**.
- Mostly **active by day**, but **nocturnal** near **human disturbance**.

- **Ecological role:** shapes vegetation, **spreads seeds**, and is key **prey for tigers**.
- **The new record (3,542 m)** suggests use of **higher habitats** than thought.

Threats and status

- **Habitat loss** and **diseases from cattle** (**rinderpest, foot-and-mouth disease**).
- **IUCN: Vulnerable**; **CITES Appendix I**; **Schedule I** of the **Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972**.
- **Value addition:** gaur were **reintroduced** into **Bandhavgarh Tiger Reserve** (2011–12) from **Kanha** after local extinction *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **species' IUCN, CITES and WPA status** and where they live.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **climate-driven range shifts** and **wildlife–livestock** disease risks.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- Consider: 1. The gaur is the largest wild bovine in the world. 2. Its IUCN status is Endangered. 3. Only male gaur have horns. Which of the statements given above is/are correct? **(Ans: 1 only)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "High-altitude sightings may be a climate signal." Discuss with reference to the gaur record from Sikkim. (150 words)

GS-III | Environment – Species in News

17. Malabar Tree Toad: Karnataka's (and India's First) State Amphibian

Syllabus: *GS-III: Conservation – endemic species, biodiversity hotspots (Western Ghats).*

CONTEXT

Karnataka became the **first state in India** to name an **official state amphibian** – the endemic **Malabar Tree Toad** (*Malenadina Mara Gantikappe* in Kannada).



A male Malabar Tree Toad on a branch in Karnataka's Western Ghats.
Photo: Harikrishnan S, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Amphibian	Cold-blooded animals that live **both in water and on land** – frogs, toads, caecilians, salamanders.
Arboreal	**Living in trees**.
Endemic	Found **only in one region** – here the **Western Ghats**.
Bufonidae	The **true toad** family.
Indicator species	A species whose health shows the **health of its ecosystem**.

About the toad

- *Pedostibes tuberculosus*, family **Bufonidae**; the **only tree-dwelling toad in India**.
- **Endemic** to the **Western Ghats** – **wet evergreen and semi-evergreen** forests at about **250 to 1,000+ m**.
- Lives in **canopies, tree holes** and **water-filled leaf bases**; comes down to streams to breed.
- **Status: Endangered** (as cited).

Key features

- **Tiny:** about **3.5–3.8 cm**, with **broad, sticky finger and toe pads** for climbing.
- **Rough, warty** brownish-grey skin with a **creamy-white stripe** from below the eye to the shoulder.
- **Breeds before the monsoon** (**March–June**), unlike most Indian frogs.

- **Tadpoles** have **sucker-like mouths** to cling to rocks in **fast streams**.
- Males give a **sharp repeated call** of about **3–7 seconds** at around **3,780 Hz**.

Why it matters

- Needs **clean streams, tree cover and moist forests** – a good **indicator** of forest health.
- Naming it a **state amphibian** draws attention to **less-known species** and to **canopy and stream protection**.
- **Value addition:** the **Western Ghats** are a **UNESCO World Heritage Site (2012)** and one of India's **four biodiversity hotspots** *(general knowledge)*.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Pattern:** Prelims asks about **endemic species**, **state symbols** and the **Western Ghats**.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** Mains asks about **biodiversity hotspots** and **conserving lesser-known species**.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- The Malabar Tree Toad, declared Karnataka's state amphibian, is: (a) found across peninsular India (b) a tree-dwelling toad endemic to the Western Ghats (c) a desert toad of Rajasthan (d) a burrowing toad of the Himalayas **(Ans: b)**

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "State symbols can be conservation tools." Discuss with reference to Karnataka's state amphibian. (150 words)

GENERAL STUDIES PAPER IV

[GS-IV] Ethics, Integrity & Aptitude

GS-IV | Ethics, Integrity & Aptitude – Synthesis

18. Ethics Synthesis: Accountability, Dignity and Evidence

Syllabus: *GS-IV: Ethics in public administration; accountability; probity; gender sensitivity; case studies.*

CONTEXT

Today's topics turn on three public-service values: **accountability for public money** (PAC), **dignity and justice for women and children** (polygamy rules, fast-track courts), and **policy based on evidence** (anaemia, statistics, poverty).



Illustration: a balance with a heart and a shield on one side and charts and coins on the other – values and evidence together.

KEYWORDS DEFINED

Keyword	Meaning
Accountability	Being **answerable** for decisions and the use of **public money**.
Dignity	The **inherent worth** of every person, protected by **Article 21**.
Evidence-based policy	Decisions grounded in **reliable data and tested results**.
Precautionary principle	Avoid actions that may cause **serious harm** when the evidence is **uncertain**.
Procedural fairness	A fair process – **hearing both sides**, no bias, reasons given.

The ethical thread

- **Accountability:** the **PAC** reminds officials that **every rupee** must be **justified** to the people's representatives.
- **Dignity and justice: fast-track courts** and **service rules on polygamy** aim to protect **women and children** – but **speed and enforcement** must respect **fair process**.
- **Evidence and caution: iron-fortified salt** shows why we **pilot before scaling** – **'first, do no harm'**.
- **Equity:** poverty has fallen, but **security, health and opportunity** remain **unequal**.
- **Duty to youth:** a revamped **Agnipath** shows **listening** to those who serve.

Values at stake

- **Accountability, integrity, dignity, fairness, compassion, prudence, transparency, objectivity.**

Case study 1: The salt roll-out

- **Situation:** As **District Health Officer**, you are told to **distribute double-fortified salt** to every household within a month. Your team notes many **thalassaemia** patients and **high malaria** in some blocks.
- **Issues: orders vs safety**; **targets vs outcomes**; informed consent.
- **Options:** (a) roll out everywhere to meet the target; (b) refuse outright; (c) **report the risks in writing**, propose **screening and a phased pilot** with **ferritin and inflammation checks**, and hold back in **high-risk blocks** until cleared.
- **Preferred course: (c) – prudence and accountability**: serve the scheme's goal without **harming the vulnerable**.

Case study 2: The audit para

- **Situation:** As **finance secretary** of a state department, you find an **audit objection** on **excess spending** by a powerful minister's project. You are asked to **'delay' the Action Taken Note** until after the elections.
- **Issues: integrity vs loyalty**; legislative oversight.
- **Options:** (a) delay as asked; (b) leak it to the media; (c) **prepare a truthful ATN on time**, record the facts, and **brief the minister** on the legal duty and corrective steps.
- **Preferred course: (c)** – the **PAC's oversight** is part of the **constitutional chain of accountability**.

Case study 3: The fast-track judge

- **Situation:** As an **FTSC judge**, you are pressed to **finish 165 cases a year**. In one POCSO case, the **forensic report** is pending and the defence seeks time.
- **Issues: speed vs fair trial**; child welfare.
- **Options:** (a) decide without the report; (b) adjourn indefinitely; (c) **fix a short, firm date**, **direct the lab** to report, and keep the child's testimony in a **VWDC** to avoid repeated trauma.
- **Preferred course: (c) – justice delayed** and **justice hurried** both fail the survivor.

Thinkers to quote (paraphrased)

- **Dr B.R. Ambedkar:** constitutional morality must be **cultivated**, not assumed.
- **Hippocratic principle: first, do no harm**.
- **Amartya Sen:** development is the **expansion of real freedoms**, not just income.
- **Mahatma Gandhi:** recall the **face of the poorest** before deciding.
- **Kautilya:** officials who misuse public money are like **fish drinking water** – hard to detect, so **audit** is vital.

PYQ – PRELIMS

- **Not applicable** – GS-IV is Mains-only.

PYQ – MAINS

- **Pattern:** GS-IV asks about **accountability, probity**, **gender sensitivity** and **case studies** on pressure from superiors.

FQ – PRELIMS (Possible Question)

- **Not applicable** – GS-IV is Mains-only.

FQ – MAINS (Possible Question)

- "Accountability is the price of authority." Discuss with examples from public administration. (150 words)
- Case study: As a District Health Officer asked to roll out double-fortified salt quickly despite health risks, what would you do and why? (250 words)